FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

THE CAR RIDE HOME

What to say when they don't make the team

09

THE QUICK VERSION

> Few moments sting like missing out on a team. The words you choose on that drive home can shape whether your child walks away thinking "I'm not good enough" or "I've got things to work on." One coach's opinion doesn't change the effort and hard work they've already put in.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Selection is one coach's view, of one squad, on one day. It isn't a verdict on your child's worth or their future in the game. Right now they need to feel safe and supported. Later, when they're ready, you can help them turn disappointment into a plan. Remember: setbacks are what make champions.

YOUR CAR RIDE GAME PLAN

1

FIRST 5 MINUTES: SAY LESS

"I'm so proud of you for trying out. I'm here." Silence, music or a snack is completely okay.

2

THAT NIGHT: LISTEN

"How are you feeling about it?" Let them vent. Validate the feeling, don't argue with it.

3

A FEW DAYS LATER: PLAN

"Want to ask the coach what to work on?" Turn the feedback into two or three goals.

"Not selected" does not mean "not good enough"

It means not this team, not this time. Their effort, their hard work and their growth already happened, and nothing takes that away. Many great players were overlooked early on and came back stronger.

TRY THIS

1 Ask for feedback
Help them ask the coach (or ask together): "What should I work on to be ready next time?"

2 Pick two or three focus areas
Fitness, weaker foot, confidence on the ball. Small, specific and achievable.

3 Make a simple plan
A couple of extra touches a week at the park, a clinic, or Future Baller sessions.

4 Look for other doors
Another team, another trial, another season. There's almost always a next opportunity.

5 Check in and celebrate
Every few weeks, notice the progress. Small wins build big confidence.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"I'm proud of how hard you worked for this."	~~"That coach doesn't know what they're doing."~~
"This doesn't change all the work you've put in."	~~"Maybe football just isn't for you."~~
"What do you want to work on next?"	~~"You should have tried harder at the trial."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My first words in the car are about pride, not the result
- [ ] I let my child feel disappointed before we make a plan
- [ ] We've turned feedback into two or three clear goals
- [ ] My child knows one decision doesn't define them

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

"Plenty of professional players were cut, overlooked or told they weren't ready. Setbacks are what make champions. What matters is what you do next."

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM

Success occurs when opportunity meets preparation.